

abate *v.* to become less intense or widespread; to reduce something

aberration *n.* a departure from what is normal or expected

abhor *v.* to regard with disgust and hatred

abstain *v.* to choose not to do or take something

accolade *n.* an award, or an expression of praise

acumen *n.* sharp judgment and quick insight

adamant *adj.* refusing to be persuaded; unshakably firm

admonish *v.* to warn or reprimand gently but firmly

adversity *n.* a difficult or unpleasant situation

aesthetic *adj.* concerned with beauty, or with the appreciation of beauty

affable *adj.* friendly and easy to talk to

alleviate *v.* to make pain or a problem less severe

aloof *adj.* distant and uninvolved; emotionally cool

altruism *n.* unselfish concern for the welfare of others

ambiguous *adj.* open to more than one interpretation; unclear

ambivalent *adj.* having mixed or contradictory feelings about something

anachronism *n.* something placed in the wrong historical period

analogous *adj.* comparable in some useful respect

anecdote *n.* a short personal story used to illustrate a point

animosity *n.* strong hostility or ill will

anomaly *n.* something that deviates from the standard or expected

antipathy *n.* a deep-seated dislike

apathy *n.* lack of interest, enthusiasm, or

concern

appease *v.* to pacify someone by giving in to their demands

arbitrary *adj.* based on personal whim rather than reason or rule

arcane *adj.* understood by very few; mysteriously obscure

arduous *adj.* requiring great effort; strenuous

articulate *adj.* able to express thoughts clearly and fluently

ascetic *n.* a person who practices severe self-discipline and abstinence

assiduous *adj.* showing great care and persistent effort

astute *adj.* shrewd; quick to see an advantage

audacious *adj.* boldly daring, sometimes to the point of recklessness

augment *v.* to make greater by adding to it

auspicious *adj.* suggesting a favorable outcome; promising

austere *adj.* severely simple and plain; stern in manner

banal *adj.* so unoriginal as to be boring

belie *v.* to give a false impression of; to contradict

benevolent *adj.* kind and generous toward others

bolster *v.* to support or strengthen

brevity *n.* shortness of speech or writing; conciseness

cacophony *n.* a harsh, discordant mixture of sounds

candid *adj.* truthful and straightforward, even when it is awkward

capricious *adj.* given to sudden changes of mood or behavior

castigate *v.* to reprimand severely

caustic *adj.* biting sarcasm; corrosive

censure *v.* to express strong formal dis-

approval

circumspect *adj.* cautious; wary of risk and consequence

clandestine *adj.* kept secret, usually because it is improper

coalesce *v.* to come together to form one whole

cogent *adj.* clear, logical, and convincing

complacent *adj.* smugly satisfied, and so unaware of danger

conciliatory *adj.* intended to placate or win goodwill

condone *v.* to accept or overlook behavior that is wrong

conundrum *n.* a confusing and difficult problem

corroborate *v.* to confirm with supporting evidence

credulous *adj.* too ready to believe things; easily deceived

cryptic *adj.* mysterious in meaning; deliberately obscure

culpable *adj.* deserving blame

cursor *adj.* hasty and not thorough

dearth *n.* a scarcity or lack of something

debunk *v.* to expose the falseness of a claim or belief

decorum *n.* behavior that is proper and in good taste

deference *n.* polite respect, and submission to another's judgment

deleterious *adj.* causing harm or damage

delineate *v.* to describe or outline precisely

deride *v.* to mock or ridicule with contempt

desultory *adj.* lacking a plan or purpose; jumping from one thing to another

deter *v.* to discourage someone from acting, usually by instilling doubt

diatribe *n.* a bitter, forceful verbal attack

didactic *adj.* intended to teach, often in a

heavy-handed moral way

diffident *adj.* shy and lacking self-confidence

digress *v.* to stray from the main subject

dilatory *adj.* slow to act; causing delay

disparage *v.* to belittle or speak of slightly

disparate *adj.* essentially different and unrelated

dissemble *v.* to hide one's true motives or feelings

docile *adj.* easily managed and willing to be taught

dogmatic *adj.* asserting opinions as if they were beyond question

dubious *adj.* doubtful; questionable in quality or truth

ebullient *adj.* overflowing with enthusiasm and energy

eclectic *adj.* drawing on a wide and varied range of sources

efficacy *n.* the power to produce the intended result

egregious *adj.* outstandingly bad; shockingly wrong

elicit *v.* to draw out a response or reaction

eloquent *adj.* fluent and persuasive in speech or writing

elucidate *v.* to make clear by explaining

emulate *v.* to imitate, especially in order to match or surpass

enervate *v.* to drain of energy and vitality

engender *v.* to give rise to; to bring about

enigma *n.* a person or thing that is mysterious and hard to understand

ephemeral *adj.* lasting a very short time

equanimity *n.* calmness and composure under strain

erudite *adj.* having or showing deep scholarly knowledge

esoteric *adj.* understood only by a small group with special knowledge

eulogy *n.* a speech of high praise, especially for someone who has died

euphemism *n.* a mild word substituted for one thought harsh or blunt

exacerbate *v.* to make a bad situation worse

exemplary *adj.* serving as a desirable model; outstandingly good

exhaustive *adj.* thorough and complete, leaving nothing out

exonerate *v.* to clear of blame or accusation